

MPAA vs the World

The MPAA (Motion Picture Association of America) is wading through troubled waters as it finds itself engaged in more than one copyright case. It already lost a case against a Russian Software company, whose product allows consumers to turn off security settings in Adobe Systems' e-books, allowing the books to be shared between users and computing devices. Charged with violating the Digital Millennium Copyright Act, the company was cleared on all counts. The MPAA is also up against Missouri software firm, 321 Studios, alleging that the company's DVD-copying software violates established anti-copying laws. Meanwhile, lobbyists for large technology companies plan to argue against efforts in the US

Congress to amend certain laws designed to broaden the rights of consumers by granting rights over digital media such as backing up DVDs for personal use, or allowing them to copy songs onto handheld devices. Although such rights are considered fair in dealing with traditional media such as audio and video tapes, the groups feel that the same courtesy should not be extended to the digital medium due to rampant sharing of files. While lobbyists from both sides agree that strict law enforcement against such digital piracy is the call of the hour, the bone of contention lies in the execution of the said measures. The RIAA (Recording Industry Association of America) intends to argue against government requirements to build locking



ILLUSTRATIONS: Mahesh Benkar

controls into the future generation of entertainment devices. These controls will make it more difficult to share copyrighted entertainment. The group contends that the controls will be too expensive to implement, a point of view that is also shared by powerful technology groups such as Microsoft, Apple, Adobe, IBM, HP and Dell. This posturing isolates the powerful MPAA which has aggressively supported requirements for built-in controls on new digital entertainment devices.

E-mail clients to filter sign-ups

Web robots are known to commonly harvest e-mail addresses, send off mailers, spawn hoards of junk messages and accumulate free e-mail accounts. Now free e-mail service providers such as Yahoo! and Hotmail use a technology developed by Carnegie Mellon University to differentiate between a bot and a human, to prevent the former from acquiring free e-mail addresses. The technology called captchas (completely automated public Turing tests to tell computers and humans apart) is based on the Turing test, which aims to differentiate between humans and intelligent computers.

Yahoo! currently uses a product called Gimpy that mangles up one word from an 850-word dictionary in such a way that only a human can identify it in the midst of distracting spots and blotches.



redalert

You've got Yaha

A new contagious variant of the Yaha virus has infected thousands of computers worldwide. The virus, dubbed W32/Yaha.M by MessageLabs, has seen its numbers explode with over 17,000 being detected by MessageLabs, making it the fifth most common virus. The worm arrives in the form of an EXE or SCR attachment in an e-mail with a variety of subjects and messages, and has its own e-mail client to mail itself, forging the 'From' address. It also attempts to close down a number of firewalls and anti-virus programs. Norton AntiVirus has an update to remove this strain. You can also download a free removal tool from www.bitdefender.com.

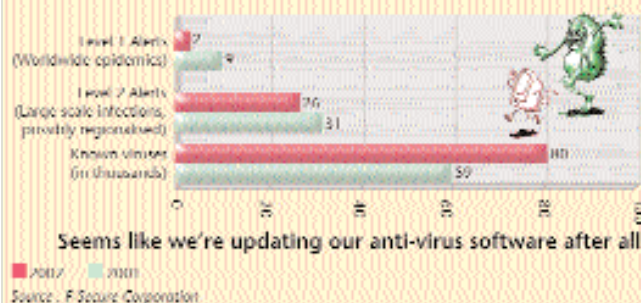
Music virus

Security company, Foundstone, located in California, identifies MP3 and Windows Media files as Trojans that could contain malicious code that leave the owner's PC open to attack. The corrupt files show no change in audio quality. "The vulnerability lies in the Windows Shell, and Microsoft's Windows Media Player is not affected," said Microsoft in an advisory posted on its Web site. WinAmp has a similar flaw, affecting Winamp player versions 2.81 and 3.0, which allows code to run when certain multimedia tags in MP3 and WMA files are loaded with too much data.

Foundstone has alerted Nullsoft which has released patched-up versions of Winamp 2.81 and Winamp 3.0 on its Web site.

statattack

Virus outbreaks seemingly under control in 2002



Internet filters block many useful sites



Source: IDC

INFOGRAPHICS: Sachin Davi

■ SGI to sell a new system running Linux on as many as 64 Itanium 2 processors ■ IBM will help AMD develop future chip technologies